Who Rules Britain? Sovereignty, Crown and People

English · Terminale · tronc commun B2, C1 tasks · spécialité LLCER towards C1 · 14 lessons of 55 minutes

Student sheet: documents, exercises, language, flashcard method, assessments and self-correction grids. Answer keys are on the website.

Framework

Problem

Is the United Kingdom governed by its King, its Parliament, its courts or its people? And can a country with no single written constitution protect democracy?

Curriculum

Terminale, theme 6 « The United Kingdom and its nations » (a Kingdom still united?), with links to the political speech topic and to citizenship. This is the frame used in The King Reigns, Parliament Rules.

Levels

Tronc commun, Terminale: **B2** (the core tasks). Spécialité LLCER anglais: **towards C1** (the C1 extensions). In Première, the tronc commun target is B1+ towards B2: use The King Reigns.

Why this version is harder

- Every session starts from an **unadapted primary source**: a charter, a statute, a court judgment, a speech or a parliamentary briefing.
- Students compare **competing theories** (Dicey and Bagehot) and test them against **real crises**: Brexit, prorogation in 2019, Scottish independence.
- The tasks are **argumentative**: rebuttal, mediation of a source into French, a mock Supreme Court ruling, a debate in the Commons.
- The vocabulary is the vocabulary of constitutional debate: sovereignty, convention, accountability, legitimacy, devolution, mandate.

Assessed outcomes

Skill	B2 core	C1 extension
Reading	Identify the claim, the evidence and the tone of an authentic text.	Explain implicit assumptions and how the text could be used by opposing sides.
Speaking	Defend a position for 3 minutes with two arguments and one example.	React to an objection without notes; concede, then counter.
Writing	An organised argumentative text of 250 to 300 words.	Nuanced conclusion; hedging; register appropriate to an op-ed.
Mediation	Summarise an English source in French for a given reader.	Select and reframe information for a specific purpose.

Assessment plan

- Mid-sequence assessment after session 4 (lesson 5): /20, coefficient 1.
- Summative written test, 2 hours (lessons 12 and 13): /20, coefficient 2.
- Final task (lesson 14): /20, coefficient 2.

The eight sessions

Each session below is one 52-minute lesson, except session 6, which takes two lessons (the facts and the judgment, then the mock hearing). The timings, outcomes, stopping points and emergency exits are in the road map. All answer keys are printed under the exercises.

Lesson 1 · 52 min

Session 1 · A constitution nobody can print

Reading | Debate

You already know (The King Reigns, session 1 and session 5): the King is impartial and cannot give orders; Parliament makes the laws; Royal Assent is a formality. **Now:** where do these rules come from, if there is no written constitution?

Question: Can a country be a democracy without a written constitution?

> Parliament has "the right to make or unmake any law whatever; and, further, … no person or body is recognised by the law of England as having a right to override or set aside the legislation of Parliament."
> *A. V. Dicey, Introduction to the Study of the Law of the Constitution, 1885, chapter 1 (public domain)*

1. **Warm-up (7 min).** Students list where the "rules" of France are written (the Constitution of 1958). Then: where would you look for the rules of the UK? Answer: statutes, court decisions, conventions, works of authority.
2. **Reading Dicey (15 min).** Identify the two halves of the principle: positive (make or unmake any law) and negative (no one can override it). Why is this both a strength and a danger?
3. **Concept: convention (6 min).** A rule that is followed but not legally enforced, such as the monarch giving Royal Assent to every bill passed by Parliament. The last refusal was by Queen Anne in 1708.
4. **Mini-debate (14 min).** Motion: "This house believes the UK should adopt a written constitution." Two speakers per side, one minute each; then the floor: every other student asks a question or adds one argument.

Exercise 1.1 · Where are the rules?

Classify each item: **statute** (Act of Parliament), **court decision**, **convention** or **work of authority**. One item is not British: which one?

1. Magna Carta, 1297 version
2. The Bill of Rights 1689
3. The monarch always gives Royal Assent
4. The Prime Minister must command the confidence of the Commons
5. R (Miller) v The Prime Minister, 2019
6. Dicey, *Introduction to the Study of the Law of the Constitution*
7. The Constitution of 4 October 1958
8. The House of Lords (Hereditary Peers) Act 2026

Exercise 1.2 · The language of Dicey

Match each expression with its meaning: (1) to make or unmake a law; (2) to override; (3) to set aside; (4) to be recognised by the law; (5) an elective dictatorship.

(a) to treat a decision as having no effect; (b) to have a status accepted by the courts; (c) to pass or repeal a law; (d) an elected government so strong that nothing can stop it; (e) to use a higher authority to cancel a decision.

Homework: 120 words. "The British constitution is a strength, not a weakness." Agree or disagree, with one example. Start your flashcards (five cards).

Lesson 2 · 52 min

Session 2 · Magna Carta, 1215: myth and law

Primary source | Mediation

You already know (The King Reigns, session 2 and session 3): the story of Runnymede, the rewriting of chapter 29 in today's English, its afterlife in the Fifth Amendment and in 1948. **Now:** we do not rewrite the clause again; we read it as a legal text, and we ask who turned it into a myth, and why.

Question: Is Magna Carta a founding text of democracy, or a deal between a king and his barons?

> "No freeman shall be taken or imprisoned, or be disseised of his freehold, or liberties, or free customs, or be outlawed, or exiled, or any other wise destroyed; nor will We not pass upon him, nor condemn him, but by lawful judgment of his peers, or by the law of the land. We will sell to no man, we will not deny or defer to any man either justice or right."
> *Magna Carta, 1297 version, chapter 29 (clauses 39 and 40 of 1215). Still in force. Source: legislation.gov.uk, 25 Edw 1 cc. 1-25*

> "Magna Charta is such a fellow, that he will have no sovereign."
> *Sir Edward Coke, speech in the House of Commons, 17 May 1628, during the debates on the Petition of Right (public domain)*

1. **Close reading.** Who is protected? ("freeman": a minority in 1215.) Who makes the promise? Underline every negative: what does the accumulation suggest?
2. **Myth versus history.** The charter was annulled by the Pope within weeks. It was reissued in 1216, 1217 and 1225. Its prestige comes later, in the 17th century, and in the American colonies. In 1628, Sir Edward Coke used it against Charles I: the charter, he said, "will have no sovereign".
3. **Mediation (C1 option).** In French, 80 words: explain to a classmate in history why this clause is still quoted today, and why historians are cautious.

Exercise 2.1 · Close reading

1. How many negative words (no, not, nor) can you find in chapter 29?
2. Find the words that mean: (a) deprived of his land; (b) declared outside the protection of the law; (c) to delay.
3. Who is "We"? What is unusual about a king using this pronoun in a promise?
4. Which two guarantees are given: one for the person, one for justice?

Exercise 2.2 · Myth or history?

Say whether each statement is **history** (true) or **myth** (false), and correct the myths.

1. Magna Carta gave the vote to the people of England.
2. The Pope declared the charter void a few weeks after Runnymede.
3. Clause 39 protected every person in England, including serfs.
4. The charter was reissued several times in the 13th century.
5. Lawyers in the 17th century used it against the king.
6. King John signed Magna Carta with a pen.

Exercise 2.3 · Coke's sentence (B2, C1)

1. What figure of speech turns the charter into "a fellow"?
2. Who is the "sovereign" Coke has in mind in 1628?
3. C1: in two sentences, explain how this sentence turns a medieval deal into a principle.

Homework: find one modern speech or article that quotes Magna Carta. What is it used to justify?

Lesson 3 · 52 min

Session 3 · 1689: Parliament takes control

Primary source | Analysis

You already know (The King Reigns, session 4): the spelling of the Bill of Rights, what the King can no longer do, the Black Rod ritual. **Now:** no spelling game. We ask how the text justifies itself, and why article 9 still protects MPs in 2026.

Question: How did a revolution without a revolution change who holds power?

> "Whereas the late King James the Second by the Assistance of diverse evill Councellors Judges and Ministers imployed by him did endeavour to subvert and extirpate the Protestant Religion and the Lawes and Liberties of this Kingdome …"
> *Bill of Rights 1689, preamble (original spelling). Source: legislation.gov.uk, 1 Will & Mar Sess 2 c 2*

> "That the pretended power of suspending of laws or the execution of laws by regall authority without consent of Parlyament is illegall." … "That the freedome of speech and debates or proceedings in Parlyament ought not to be impeached or questioned in any court or place out of Parlyament."
> *Bill of Rights 1689, article 1 and article 9 (original spelling). Source: legislation.gov.uk, 1 Will & Mar Sess 2 c 2*

1. **Context.** James II, a Catholic king, is replaced by William and Mary. They accept the Bill of Rights as a condition of the throne. The preamble blames "evill Councellors", not the institution of monarchy.
2. **Analysis.** Why does the text say "pretended" power? (The king never legally had it.) What does article 9 protect, and why does it still matter for MPs today?
3. **Link.** Article 9 was at the heart of the 2019 prorogation case (session 6).

Exercise 3.1 · How the text justifies itself

1. In the preamble, who is blamed for the crisis: the monarchy, James II, or his advisers?
2. What do the verbs "subvert" and "extirpate" mean, and what image do they create?
3. Why is it clever to call the king's power "pretended" rather than "abolished"?

Exercise 3.2 · Article 9 today

Is the person protected by article 9? Answer yes or no and explain.

1. During a debate in the Commons, an MP accuses a company of hiding a safety report.
2. The same MP repeats the accusation, word for word, in a television interview the next morning.
3. A government asks a court to rule that a speech made in the Commons was illegal.

Exercise 3.3 · 1689 and 1789

Complete the comparison: who acted, what was the method, what was the result for the monarch?

Homework: compare 1689 with 1789 in France in 100 words: same goal, different method?

Lesson 4 · 52 min

Session 4 · The dignified Crown

Theory | Speaking

You already know (The King Reigns, session 5): Bagehot's two parts, summed up; the King reigns but does not rule; the Government writes the King's Speech. **Now:** Bagehot's own words, a harder sort in which some items belong to both columns, and a paradox to defend.

Question: If the King has no real power, what is he for?

> The constitution has "first, those which excite and preserve the reverence of the population, the dignified parts … and next, the efficient parts, those by which it, in fact, works and rules." The sovereign has "three rights: the right to be consulted, the right to encourage, the right to warn."
> *Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution, 1867, chapters 1 and 3 (public domain)*

1. **Sort.** Classify into dignified or efficient: the Coronation (Charles III, 6 May 2023), the King's Speech, Prime Minister's Questions, the weekly audience, Royal Assent, the Cabinet. In The King Reigns you sorted four simple items; here, justify every choice, and say which items belong to both columns.
2. **Discussion.** Is "dignified" a compliment or a criticism? Is a symbolic head of state useful in a divided country?
3. **Speaking task.** 2 minutes: "The monarchy is the most efficient part of the constitution precisely because it is dignified."

Exercise 4.1 · The harder sort

Dignified, efficient or both? Give one reason for each.

1. The Coronation, 6 May 2023
2. The King's Speech
3. Prime Minister's Questions
4. The weekly audience
5. Royal Assent
6. The Cabinet

Exercise 4.2 · Consulted, encourage or warn?

Which of the three rights is used in each situation?

1. The Prime Minister tells the King about a plan before it is announced.
2. The King says privately that a new apprenticeship scheme is an excellent idea.

3. The King asks whether a reform might divide the four nations, and suggests caution.

Next lesson: mid-sequence assessment. Homework: watch extracts of the most recent King's Speech on the UK Parliament website: who wrote it? You know the answer from The King Reigns, so go further: list three bills it announces, and say which part of the ceremony is dignified and which is efficient.

Lesson 5 · 52 min

Mid-sequence assessment (after session 4)

52 minutes | Marked /20, coefficient 1

Purpose: check that students can read an authentic source and argue before the harder sessions on Brexit, the courts and the Union.

Part A · Reading an unseen source (/10)

> "The Sovereign has, under a constitutional monarchy such as ours, three rights: the right to be consulted, the right to encourage, the right to warn. And a king of great sense and sagacity would want no others."
> *Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution, 1867, chapter 3 (public domain)*

1. Explain in your own words the three rights of the Sovereign. (3 points)
2. What does "would want no others" suggest about Bagehot's view of royal power? (2 points)
3. Give one real modern example of each right, using the weekly audience and the King's Speech. (3 points)
4. Is Bagehot describing what the monarch can do, or what the monarch should do? Justify. (2 points)

Part B · Short argument (/10)

150 to 180 words: "Magna Carta and the Bill of Rights limited the power of the King, not the power of the State." Agree or disagree, quoting at least one of the two texts.

Marking grids for the teacher and the self-correction grid for students are in the grids section.

Lesson 6 · 52 min

Session 5 · Sovereignty and the people: the Brexit paradox

Data | Argument

You already know (The King Reigns, session 8): the 2016 figures nation by nation, the turnout, the coloured map. **Now:** the figures are evidence for an argument about sovereignty, not a reading exercise.

Question: Who is sovereign when Parliament and the people disagree?

- 23 June 2016: the referendum on EU membership. Leave 51.9 %, Remain 48.1 %. England and Wales voted Leave; Scotland and Northern Ireland voted Remain.
- The referendum was legally advisory. Yet a majority of MPs had campaigned for Remain.
- Slogan of the Leave campaign: "Take back control."

1. **Analysis.** Control by whom, and from whom? Explain the paradox: a vote to restore the sovereignty of Parliament was a vote of the people that Parliament felt obliged to follow.

2. **The results by nation.** You coloured the map in The King Reigns; now interpret it: what do the results by nation reveal about the Union? Prepare the question of session 7.
3. **Writing (B2).** 180 words: "Referendums strengthen democracy." Discuss. Plan and introduction in class, the rest at home.

Exercise 5.1 · Who is sovereign?

Complete with **Parliament** or **the people**.

1. In Dicey's theory, _____ is sovereign.
2. In 2016, _____ voted to leave the European Union.
3. The referendum was advisory, so in law _____ could have ignored it.
4. In practice, _____ felt it had to follow the vote of _____.
5. "Take back control" claimed to return power to _____ at Westminster.

Exercise 5.2 · Hedging (C1)

Rewrite each statement in a more cautious, academic way: It could be argued that … / This would seem to suggest … / … may well …

1. Referendums are bad for democracy.
2. The 2016 result shows that the UK is breaking up.
3. MPs betrayed their own opinions.

Homework: finish the 180 words, then read the Burke quotation on the sources page and summarise it in one sentence.

Lessons 7 and 8 · 2 × 52 min

Session 6 · Courts versus government: prorogation, 2019

Court judgment | Role play

New ground. The King Reigns did not study the courts. Link with what you know: the King acts on the advice of the Prime Minister (The King Reigns, session 1), and article 9 of the Bill of Rights (session 3 here).

Question: Can judges stop a Prime Minister?

> The decision to advise Her Majesty to prorogue Parliament "was unlawful because it had the effect of frustrating or preventing the ability of Parliament to carry out its constitutional functions without reasonable justification."
> *R (Miller) v The Prime Minister; Cherry v Advocate General for Scotland [2019] UKSC 41, 24 September 2019, the Court's conclusion*

Lesson 7 · The facts and the judgment

1. **Facts.** In August 2019, Boris Johnson advised the Queen to suspend Parliament for five weeks before the Brexit deadline. The Supreme Court, unanimously (11 judges), declared the prorogation void. Parliament returned the next day.
2. **Discussion.** Is this the courts protecting parliamentary sovereignty, or the courts entering politics? Link with Dicey (session 1) and article 9 (session 3).

Lesson 8 · The mock hearing

3. **Mock hearing (C1).** Three groups: counsel for the government, counsel for the claimants, the judges. Each counsel speaks 3 minutes; the judges deliver a reasoned ruling. Each member of a group delivers at least one argument or one reason.

Exercise 6.1 · The timeline (lesson 7)

Put the events in order.

a. The Supreme Court declares the prorogation void.
b. Boris Johnson advises the Queen to prorogue Parliament.
c. Parliament is prorogued.
d. The Commons sit again.
e. In London, the High Court says the question is not for the courts.
f. In Edinburgh, the Inner House of the Court of Session finds the prorogation unlawful.

Exercise 6.2 · The language of the judgment (lesson 7)

Explain in simple English: (1) to prorogue; (2) unlawful; (3) frustrating or preventing; (4) constitutional functions; (5) without reasonable justification; (6) void.

Exercise 6.3 · Conditionals and inversion for the ruling (lesson 8, C1)

Rewrite with an inversion, as a judge would.

1. If the Court had not intervened, Parliament would have stayed silent for five weeks.
2. A court had never before ruled on the advice given to the monarch to prorogue.
3. Parliament not only returned the next day, but it also resumed its work at once.

Homework after lesson 7: prepare your part of the mock hearing (three sentences, one link to Dicey or to article 9).
Homework after lesson 8: 150 words: "The judges did their job." Agree or disagree.

Lesson 9 · 52 min

Session 7 · An unelected chamber and a disunited kingdom?

Current affairs | Debate

You already know (The King Reigns, session 6 and session 8): the stages of the Hereditary Peers Act 2026, devolution and the 2014 referendum. **Now:** not the path of the bill but its legitimacy; not the 2014 figures but the 2022 ruling and the clash of two ideas of sovereignty.

Question: Is the UK still one country with one Parliament?

The Lords

The House of Lords (Hereditary Peers) Act 2026 received Royal Assent on 18 March 2026. Since the end of the session on 29 April 2026, the House has been made up only of life peers and bishops (Lords Spiritual). Is an appointed chamber more legitimate than a hereditary one?

The Union

- Devolution, 1998-1999: Scottish Parliament, Welsh Assembly (now Senedd), Northern Ireland Assembly.

- Scottish independence referendum, 18 September 2014: No 55.3 %, Yes 44.7 %.
- November 2022: the UK Supreme Court rules that the Scottish Parliament cannot legislate for a new referendum without Westminster's consent.

> Without a change to the reserved matters, "the Scottish Parliament does not have the power to legislate for a referendum on Scottish independence."
> *Reference by the Lord Advocate of devolution issues [2022] UKSC 31, 23 November 2022, press summary of the unanimous judgment (short quotation, UK Supreme Court)*

1. **Reading.** Compare the "Take back control" logic of session 5 with the Scottish nationalist argument: same logic, opposite conclusion?
2. **Debate.** Motion: "Westminster should allow a second independence referendum."

Exercise 7.1 · For or against a second referendum?

Sort the arguments into **for** and **against** the motion.

1. Scotland voted Remain in 2016 and was taken out of the EU against its will.
2. The 2014 vote was presented as a once-in-a-generation decision.
3. The SNP, which supports independence, won the Scottish Parliament elections of 2016 and 2021.
4. The constitution is a reserved matter, decided at Westminster.
5. Another referendum would divide families and communities again.

Exercise 7.2 · Elected, hereditary, appointed

Complete with **elected**, **hereditary** or **appointed**.

1. MPs are _____ by the voters of their constituency.
2. Before 2026, 92 members of the Lords sat because of a _____ title.
3. Life peers are _____ by the King on the advice of the Prime Minister.
4. Critics say an _____ chamber is more legitimate than an _____ one, but less than an _____ one.

Homework: prepare a 1-minute statement as a Scottish, Welsh, Northern Irish or English MP.

Lesson 10 · 52 min

Session 8 · Votes at 16: a bill in progress

Parliamentary briefing | Final preparation

You already know (The King Reigns, session 8): the GOV.UK summary of the bill and a first debate, for or against. **Now:** the official briefing, the other provisions of the bill, and a debate where every speaker must use a figure and answer the previous speaker.

Question: Should 16-year-olds vote in general elections?

- The Representation of the People Bill was introduced in the House of Commons on 12 February 2026.
- It passed its third reading in the Commons on 2 September 2026 by 411 votes to 102. In November 2026 it is at committee stage in the House of Lords.
- It would give about 1.7 million 16- and 17-year-olds the vote. They can already vote in devolved elections in Scotland and Wales.

- The Conservative Party and Reform UK oppose the change; most other parties support it.

1. **Reading.** Read the House of Commons Library briefing (link in Sources). Identify three provisions besides votes at 16.
2. **Debate.** As a class of 16- and 17-year-olds: are you ready? Arguments on maturity, taxation, civic education, the Scottish example. Every speaker uses one figure and answers the previous speaker.
3. **Briefing for the final task.** Choose your role and your format.

Exercise 8.1 · The facts of the bill

1. The bill was introduced in the Commons on _____.
2. Third reading in the Commons: _____ votes to _____.
3. About _____ young people would gain the vote.
4. In November 2026, the bill is at _____ stage in the _____.
5. Two parties opposed to the change: _____ and _____.

Exercise 8.2 · Weighing evidence (C1)

Turn this list into one weighed sentence, using *carries more weight than*, *is outweighed by* or *admittedly … yet …*: "16-year-olds pay tax. Youth turnout is low."

This bill is still in progress: check its stage on the UK Parliament website before the lesson.

Homework: choose your final task and write its plan. Finish your flashcard pack.

Language for argument

Building your vocabulary: constitutional debate

- **sovereignty**: supreme authority; **parliamentary sovereignty**
- **convention**: unwritten rule; **Royal Assent**
- **prerogative powers**: powers exercised by ministers in the name of the Crown
- **accountability**: having to answer for one's decisions
- **legitimacy**, **mandate**, **devolution**, **to prorogue**, **to override**, **a bill** / **an Act**

Already met in The King Reigns: Royal Assent, devolution, a bill / an Act, consent, to appoint, turnout. Revise them on your flashcards; the new words are the others.

Structures B2 to C1

- Conceding then countering: *Admittedly, …; nevertheless, … · While it is true that …, it does not follow that …*
- Hedging: *It could be argued that … · This would seem to suggest …*
- Inversion for emphasis (C1): *Never before had a court … · Not only did Parliament …, but it also …*
- Third conditional and mixed conditional: *Had the Court not intervened, Parliament would still be silent.*
- Passive and impersonal forms: *The prorogation was declared void.*

Exercise L.1 · The right word

Complete with: sovereignty, convention, prerogative, accountability, legitimacy, mandate, to prorogue, to override.

1. Prime Minister's Questions is a weekly exercise in _____.
2. A government elected on a clear manifesto claims a _____ for its reforms.
3. Royal Assent is never refused: it is a _____, not a law.
4. In 2019, the Prime Minister used a _____ power _____ Parliament.
5. According to Dicey, no court can _____ an Act of Parliament.
6. An appointed chamber has less democratic _____ than an elected one.
7. For Brexit supporters, leaving the EU restored national _____.

Exercise L.2 · Concede, then counter

Join the two ideas with the structure given.

1. (Admittedly …; nevertheless …) The monarchy is expensive. / It unites the nation in times of crisis.
2. (While it is true that …, it does not follow that …) The UK has no written constitution. / Its citizens have no rights.
3. (Not only … but also …, with inversion) The Court declared the prorogation void. / It said Parliament had never been prorogued.

My bristol flashcards · how to use them

From The King Reigns. If you made a pack in The King Reigns, keep it: those cards go straight into box 3 after one check. Make new cards only for the new words, sources and structures below.

Principle. Each student makes their own cards by hand, on bristol cards. Writing the word is already a way of learning it. The pack stays in the bag, so students can revise anywhere, with no screen. There is no ready-made deck: this page gives the method, a few model cards and a blank template.

Materials

A7 bristol cards (74 × 105 mm), about 25 per student, or A6 bristols cut in half. Felt-tip pens in four colours. An elastic band or an envelope for the pack. A small cardboard box with three compartments for practice (a shoe box with two dividers is enough). You can also print the blank template and cut it out.

What goes on a card

	What to write
Front	One English word, phrase, date or structure, in the colour of its category.
Back	A short meaning in English (a French translation only if you need it) and one example sentence of your own, linked to Who Rules Britain?.
Corner	The category and the session where you met the item.
Check	Can I give the meaning and an example without turning the card over?

Colour code

Category	**Pen colour**
Vocabulary	green
Structures and grammar	red

Primary sources and quotations	blue
Dates and figures	purple

When to make the cards

When	Cards to make
End of lessons 1, 2, 3, 6, 7 and 9	Four or five cards: the new words and the key quotation of the session (homework).
Lesson 4, before the mid-sequence assessment	Revise sessions 1 to 4 with your cards; add one card for each primary source.
Lesson 11, revision workshop	Finish the pack (20 cards or more), then practise in pairs with three boxes.
Before the written test and the final task	Ten minutes a day with box 1 and box 2.

Practice in pairs, with three boxes

Student A shows the front; student B gives the meaning and a sentence. A card that is right moves on one box. A card that is wrong goes back to box 1. Target before the final task: 15 cards in box 3.

Model cards

What to put on cards

Choose the items you still hesitate on. One item per card. Do not copy the whole list.

- **Vocabulary:** sovereignty, convention, prerogative powers, accountability, legitimacy, mandate, devolution, to prorogue, to override, to set aside, due process, parliamentary privilege, reserved matter, life peer, advisory referendum
- **Primary sources:** Magna Carta ch. 29 (1297); Coke 1628; Bill of Rights 1689, preamble, articles 1 and 9; Burke 1774; Bagehot 1867; Dicey 1885; Miller 2019; the 2022 Scottish reference
- **Structures:** Admittedly …; nevertheless …; While it is true that …, it does not follow that …; It could be argued that …; Never before had …; Not only did …, but …; Had … not …, … would …
- **Dates and figures:** 1215, 1628, 1689, 1708, 1885, 2014 (55.3 %), 2016 (51.9 %, turnout 72.2 %), 24 September 2019, November 2022, 18 March 2026, 411 to 102

Grid · my pack of cards /10

Criterion	Points
20 cards or more, with the colour code respected	/ 2
Clear handwriting, correct spelling on the front and the back	/ 3
A precise example of your own on the back (not only a translation)	/ 3
Check: the teacher draws five cards and the student answers (four right answers or more = 2 points)	/ 2

Lessons 12 and 13 · 2 × 52 min, or one 2-hour exam slot

Summative assessment (end of sequence)

The summative assessment has two parts, marked separately, so that both written and oral skills are assessed.

Part	Format	Weight
1. Written test, in class	Reading of two unseen sources + argumentative essay, 2 hours (or lessons 12 and 13)	/20, coefficient 2
2. Final task	Speech, op-ed or mock ruling (see below), lesson 14	/20, coefficient 2

Part 1 · Written test (2 hours)

Document A: extract from the Supreme Court judgment of 24 September 2019 (the Court's conclusion, about 150 words). Document B: the summary of the Representation of the People Bill on GOV.UK ("Votes at 16" policy summary, first two paragraphs).

Documents A and B are not reproduced here. Print them on the day from the UK Supreme Court page (judgment, final paragraphs) and from GOV.UK. Document A is "unseen" only in part: students know the conclusion quoted in session 6, so choose the paragraphs that come just before it.

1. Comprehension, Document A (/5): what was the government's decision, why did the Court find it unlawful, and what principle did it protect?
2. Comprehension, Document B (/5): list the main changes proposed and explain the reason the government gives.
3. Mediation in French (/4): in 100 words, explain to your French parents why judges in the UK were able to cancel a decision of the Prime Minister.
4. Essay (/6), 250 to 300 words: "In the United Kingdom, the people are sovereign in theory but Parliament is sovereign in practice." Discuss, using at least two examples from the sequence.

In two lessons: questions 1 to 3 in lesson 12, the essay in lesson 13.

Lesson 14 · 52 min

Summative part 2 · Final task: "Who rules Britain?"

A step up from The King Reigns. There, the speech lasted 3 minutes and the op-ed 250 to 300 words on Magna Carta. Here, the speech is followed by 2 minutes of questions, the op-ed is longer and on a new question, and a third, C1 option is added.

Students choose one of three tasks. All three require using at least **three primary sources** from the sequence and answering **one objection**.

1. **Speech in the Commons (4 minutes + 2 minutes of questions).** You are a newly elected MP. Speak for or against the Representation of the People Bill, or for or against a written constitution.
2. **Op-ed (350 to 400 words).** For a British newspaper: "Britain needs a written constitution." Argue for or against.
3. **Mock Supreme Court ruling (C1, in pairs).** Write and present a short judgment (300 words) on an invented case: a government suspends Parliament for three months during a national emergency.

In lesson 14, op-eds are handed in at the start; speeches and rulings are delivered (about seven per lesson); op-ed writers ask the questions. With a larger group, the remaining speeches open the next lessons, two per lesson.

Self-correction grids for students

Mid-sequence assessment

Before I hand in, I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I explained the three rights in my own words, without copying the text.	☐	☐	☐
I gave a modern example for each right.	☐	☐	☐
My argument has a clear position in the first sentence.	☐	☐	☐
I quoted Magna Carta or the Bill of Rights correctly, with quotation marks.	☐	☐	☐
I used at least one concession (Admittedly…, nevertheless…).	☐	☐	☐
I checked verbs (tense, -s at the third person) and spelling.	☐	☐	☐

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Summative written test

Before I hand in, I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I answered every question about Document A and Document B.	☐	☐	☐
My mediation is in French, adapted to my parents, and is not a translation.	☐	☐	☐
My essay has an introduction with the question, two parts and a conclusion.	☐	☐	☐
I used two examples from the sequence (Brexit, 2019 ruling, Scotland, votes at 16).	☐	☐	☐
I used vocabulary such as sovereignty, Parliament, mandate, accountability.	☐	☐	☐
I wrote between 250 and 300 words for the essay.	☐	☐	☐

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Final task

Before I hand in, I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I chose one format and respected its length or time.	☐	☐	☐
I used three primary sources from the sequence.	☐	☐	☐
I answered one objection.	☐	☐	☐
I used at least two complex structures (inversion, conditional, passive).	☐	☐	☐
For the speech: I rehearsed and can speak without reading.	☐	☐	☐
For the op-ed or ruling: I reread for accuracy and register.	☐	☐	☐

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Sources

- Magna Carta (1297): legislation.gov.uk, chapter 29
- Bill of Rights 1689 (preamble, articles 1 and 9): legislation.gov.uk

- A. V. Dicey, Introduction to the Study of the Law of the Constitution (1885), and Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution (1867): public domain, available on Project Gutenberg (Bagehot).
- Sir Edward Coke, speech in the House of Commons, 17 May 1628: "Magna Charta is such a fellow, that he will have no sovereign" (public domain; recorded in the parliamentary debates of 1628).
- Edmund Burke, Speech to the Electors of Bristol (1774): "Your representative owes you, not his industry only, but his judgment; and he betrays, instead of serving you, if he sacrifices it to your opinion."
- Lord Hailsham, "elective dictatorship", Richard Dimbleby Lecture, 1976 (phrase quoted only).
- R (Miller) v The Prime Minister [2019] UKSC 41: UK Supreme Court
- Reference by the Lord Advocate of devolution issues [2022] UKSC 31: UK Supreme Court (short quotation from the press summary)
- House of Lords (Hereditary Peers) Act 2026 and House of Commons Library, Peerages and membership of the House of Lords
- House of Commons Library, Representation of the People Bill: progress of the bill
- GOV.UK, Votes at 16 policy summary
- Electoral Commission, briefings on the bill

Facts on current bills checked on 11 November 2026. Check the stage of the Representation of the People Bill before teaching session 8.

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